AppealDesk

# Your Homeowner Savings Guide

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## Property Tax Exemptions & Credits You May Qualify For

Based on your property in Berkeley County, South Carolina, we have identified the following property tax exemption and credit programs that may apply to you. Each program listed below includes eligibility requirements, estimated savings, and instructions for how to apply. *Since we do not collect personal information such as age or veteran status, each program below is listed as "If you qualify..." so you can identify which programs may apply to your household.*

4% Owner-Occupied Assessment Ratio

Owner-occupied homes are assessed at 4% of market value instead of 6% for other residential property. This is the most important tax benefit for South Carolina homeowners and is effectively a 33% reduction in your tax base.

**Estimated Savings: $500-$1,500/year (vs. 6% non-owner-occupied rate)**

**Eligibility:** Must own and occupy the property as your legal residence. Must apply with your county assessor.
**Deadline:** Within 90 days of moving into the property
**Form:** Application through county assessor
**Apply:** https://dor.sc.gov/tax/property
This is the single most valuable property tax benefit in South Carolina. Make sure your property is correctly classified at the 4% owner-occupied rate. If it is classified at 6%, you are significantly overpaying.

Homestead Exemption for Seniors

Exempts the first $50,000 of fair market value from all property taxes for homeowners 65 and older.

**Estimated Savings: $400-$1,000/year**

**Eligibility:** Must be 65 or older and a legal resident of South Carolina. Must own and occupy the property as your legal residence.
**Deadline:** Apply to your county auditor on or before July 15
**Form:** Application through county auditor
**Apply:** https://dor.sc.gov/tax/property
No income limit. This is a full exemption on the first $50,000 of market value, saving significant taxes. Once approved, does not need annual renewal.

Disabled Veteran Exemption

Permanently and totally disabled veterans are exempt from all property taxes on their legal residence. Former POWs are also exempt.

Estimated Savings: Full property tax exemption

**Eligibility:** Must have a permanent and total service-connected disability. Must be a legal resident of South Carolina.
**Deadline:** Apply to county auditor
**Form:** Application through county auditor
**Apply:** https://dor.sc.gov/tax/property
Surviving spouses of qualifying veterans may also be eligible. Must provide VA disability documentation.

Homestead Exemption for Disabled Persons
Same $50,000 exemption as the senior exemption, available to permanently and totally disabled persons of any age.

Estimated Savings: $400-$1,000/year

**Eligibility:** Must be permanently and totally disabled. Must own and occupy the property as legal residence.
**Deadline:** July 15
**Form:** Application through county auditor
**Apply:** https://dor.sc.gov/tax/property
Same program as the senior exemption. Disability must be verified by SSA, VA, or a licensed physician.

Surviving Spouse
South Carolina does not have a separate widow/widower exemption. Surviving spouses of disabled veterans may qualify for the disabled veteran exemption.

Assessment Cap (15% per 5-Year Reassessment Cycle)
Property value increases are capped at 15% per reassessment cycle. Reassessments occur every 5 years in most counties.

Estimated Savings: Varies; protects against sharp value spikes

**Eligibility:** Automatic for all owner-occupied property at the 4% rate.
**Deadline:** Automatic
The cap is reset when a property is sold (new owner gets a new base value). This is separate from the 4% assessment ratio and stacks on top of it.

Agricultural Use (Special Assessment)
Agricultural real property is assessed at 4% of its use value rather than market value.

Estimated Savings: Significant reduction based on use value vs. market value

**Eligibility:** Must be used for agricultural purposes and meet county requirements.

Source: https://dor.sc.gov/tax/property

**These programs are independent of your property assessment.** You can apply for exemptions regardless of whether you file a property tax appeal. Even if your assessment is accurate, you may be overpaying taxes simply because you have not applied for exemptions you qualify for.

Exemption programs and eligibility requirements change periodically. The information above is current as of 2026-03. Verify current requirements with your county assessor's office before applying.

# Reassessment Protection Guide

Understanding what triggers a reassessment of your property can help you protect your current assessed value and avoid unexpected tax increases.

## Actions That May Trigger Reassessment

- **Building permits:** Pulling a permit for renovations, additions, or structural changes will typically notify the assessor of improvements to your property.
- **Major visible renovations:** Exterior improvements such as new roofing, siding, additions, or added structures (pools, garages, ADUs) may prompt a reassessment even without a permit.
- **Listing on MLS:** Listing your home for sale, even temporarily, can expose a higher market value to the assessor, especially if the listing price significantly exceeds your current assessed value.
- **Refinance appraisals:** In some jurisdictions, a high appraisal obtained during refinancing can become part of the public record and influence your assessment.
- **Insurance rebuild valuations:** Replacement cost estimates from insurance claims can signal a higher property value.
- **Adding structures:** Pools, accessory dwelling units (ADUs), detached garages, and other permanent structures increase your property's value.

## How to Protect Your Current Assessment

- **Document your home's current condition:** Take dated photos showing any deferred maintenance, needed repairs, or functional issues. This documentation can support a lower valuation if challenged.
- **Keep records of needed repairs:** Maintain a list of deferred maintenance items (aging HVAC, roof wear, plumbing issues). These reduce your home's value relative to comparable properties.
- **Understand your reassessment schedule:** Know when your county's next reassessment year is so you are not caught off guard by changes.
- **Review your annual assessment notice:** When you receive your notice of assessed value, compare it to the prior year and to recent comparable sales in your neighborhood.

**Your state's reassessment cycle:** South Carolina reassesses property on a annual basis. Understanding this cycle helps you anticipate when your assessment might change.

## What to Do If Your Assessment Increases

If your assessed value increases significantly, you have the right to appeal. The key steps are:

- Review your appeal deadline (see the Appeal Window section of this packet)
- Gather comparable sales data showing your home's actual market value
- Document any property-specific factors that reduce value (condition issues, location drawbacks, functional obsolescence)
- File your appeal before the deadline

AppealDesk can generate a comprehensive evidence packet if your assessment rises in the future. Visit https://www.appealdesk.com to get started.

## Understanding Your Property Tax Bill

Your property tax bill includes more than just the base property tax. Understanding each component helps you identify which charges can be challenged and where potential savings exist.

Your Tax Breakdown at a Glance
Based on your current assessment of **$7,242** and annual tax of **$863.65**, your effective tax rate is approximately **0.31%**.
The effective rate includes all taxing jurisdictions (school district, county, city, and special districts) combined.

### How Your Tax Is Calculated

The core formula is: **Assessed Value x Tax Rate = Base Property Tax**. Your total bill then adds special district assessments, voter-approved bonds, and various fees on top of this base amount.

### Common Line Items You May See

- **School district levy:** Typically the largest portion (often 40-50% of total). Funds local public schools and sometimes community colleges.
- **County general fund:** Covers county services including roads, courts, public safety, and administration.
- **City/municipal tax:** Funds city services such as police, fire, parks, and infrastructure. Only applies if you live within city limits.
- **Fire/emergency services district:** Funds local fire protection and emergency medical services. Common in unincorporated areas.
- **Library district:** Funds local library operations and programs.
- **Stormwater/drainage fees:** Based on impervious surface area. Some jurisdictions bill these separately from the tax bill.
- **Voter-approved bonds:** Debt service on bonds approved by voters for schools, infrastructure, parks, or other public projects.
- **Solid waste assessment:** Some jurisdictions include trash collection fees on the property tax bill.
- **Special improvement districts:** Charges for lighting, sidewalks, or other neighborhood-level improvements.

### Which Charges Can Be Challenged?

Challengeable **Ad valorem (value-based) taxes:** The core property tax based on your assessed value. This is what a property tax appeal addresses. Reducing your assessed value reduces this portion of your bill proportionally.

Separate Process **Special assessments and fees:** Flat-rate charges for specific services (stormwater, solid waste, special districts) often have their own dispute process. Contact your county for details.

Not Challengeable **Voter-approved bonds:** Bond levies approved at the ballot box generally cannot be individually challenged through the appeal process.

### Where Your Tax Dollars Typically Go

While the exact breakdown varies by jurisdiction, a typical distribution of property tax revenue is:

| ~45% | ~25% | ~15% | ~15% |
|---|---|---|---|
| Schools | County Services | City/Municipal | Special Districts |

These are national averages. Your jurisdiction's breakdown may differ. Check your tax bill or county website for the exact distribution.

## Energy Savings & Rebate Finder

Beyond property tax savings, significant financial incentives are available for home energy improvements. Many homeowners are unaware of these programs, which can save hundreds to thousands of dollars per year on energy costs.

### Federal Programs (Available Nationwide)

Energy Efficient Home Improvement Credit (25C)
Tax credit of up to $3,200/year for qualifying home energy improvements including insulation, exterior doors, windows, central air conditioners, heat pumps, water heaters, and electrical panel upgrades.

**Up to $3,200/year ($1,200 general limit + $2,000 for heat pumps/heat pump water heaters)**

**Eligibility:** Available to all homeowners for improvements to their primary residence. Must meet ENERGY STAR or other efficiency standards.
**How to claim:** Claim on your federal tax return using IRS Form 5695. Keep receipts and manufacturer certification statements.
Available through: Through December 31, 2032
**Details:** https://www.energystar.gov/about/federal_tax_credits/tax_credits_702

Residential Clean Energy Credit (25D)
30% tax credit on the cost of solar panels, solar water heaters, battery storage, geothermal heat pumps, fuel cells, and small wind turbines.

**30% of total system cost (no maximum limit)**

**Eligibility:** Available to homeowners for installations on any home they own (primary or secondary). Must be a new installation, not previously used.
**How to claim:** Claim on your federal tax return using IRS Form 5695. Unused credit can carry forward to future tax years.
Available through: 30% through 2032, then 26% in 2033, 22% in 2034
**Details:**
https://www.energystar.gov/about/federal_tax_credits/renewable_energy_tax_credits

High-Efficiency Electric Home Rebate Act (HEEHRA)
Point-of-sale rebates for electrification upgrades: up to $8,000 for heat pumps, $1,750 for heat pump water heaters, $840 for electric stoves/dryers, $4,000 for electrical panel upgrades, and $1,600 for insulation.

**Up to $14,000 total in rebates per household**

**Eligibility:** Income-qualified: households earning less than 150% of area median income get the largest rebates. Moderate-income households (150-200% AMI) get

50% rebates. Above 200% AMI are not eligible for HEEHRA rebates.
**How to claim:** Applied as a point-of-sale discount through participating contractors. Check with your state energy office for availability.
Available through: Funds available until September 30, 2031 or until exhausted
**Details:** https://www.energy.gov/scep/home-energy-rebates-programs

### South Carolina Programs

South Carolina Solar Tax Credit
State tax credit of 25% of the cost of a solar energy system, up to $3,500 per year (or 50% of tax liability, whichever is less). Unused credit carries forward up to 10 years.
**Details:** https://dor.sc.gov/tax/solar-energy
One of the more generous state solar credits. Combined with the federal 30% credit, total incentives can exceed 50% of system cost.

Utility Rebate Programs
Dominion Energy SC and Duke Energy Carolinas offer rebates for energy-efficient equipment and home energy audits.
Contact your specific utility for current rebate offerings.

Contact Dominion Energy South Carolina, Duke Energy Carolinas, or your local electric cooperative for available energy efficiency rebates.

### Where to Start

For maximum savings, energy efficiency experts recommend this order of improvements:

1. **Air sealing and insulation first.** This has the highest return on investment and enables right-sizing of HVAC equipment. Typical savings: 15-30% on heating and cooling costs.
2. **HVAC heat pump upgrade.** Heat pumps provide both heating and cooling, qualify for the largest rebates, and can reduce energy costs by 30-50% compared to traditional systems.
3. **Water heater replacement.** Heat pump water heaters use 60-70% less energy than conventional models and qualify for substantial rebates.

Federal tax credits require filing IRS Form 5695 with your annual tax return. State and utility programs may have different application processes. Program availability and amounts are subject to change. Consult with a tax professional regarding your specific eligibility.

## Property Tax Watch: Never Overpay Again

You have taken the first step by understanding your current assessment. Property Tax Watch ensures you stay ahead of any future changes, with automatic monitoring and alerts when your assessment increases.

- ✓ **Annual assessment change alerts** delivered to your inbox when your county updates your property value
- ✓ **Automatic overassessment detection** comparing your assessed value against current market data
- ✓ **Filing deadline reminders** so you never miss your window to appeal

**Activate Your Free 12-Month Monitoring**

https://www.appealdesk.com/tax-watch

## Appeal Window & Deadline Summary

In South Carolina, the process for challenging your property assessment is called an "appeal." Here is what you need to know about timing and deadlines for Berkeley County.

Mark Your Calendar
**South Carolina Appeal Deadline:** 90 days from notice
**Review Board:** County Assessor
**County:** Berkeley County, South Carolina

The typical appeal window in South Carolina is **Year-round (reassessment years)**. During this period, homeowners can file a formal appeal of their assessed property value.

When Your Appeal Window Opens
Your appeal window typically opens when you receive your **Notice of Assessment** from the county. This notice is mailed to property owners, usually in the spring.
**Keep this notice.** You will need it to file your appeal. It contains your property identification number, current assessed value, and instructions for filing.

### South Carolina Appeal Process

If you choose to appeal, the process follows these levels:

1. County Assessor (Informal)
2. County Board of Assessment Appeals
3. Administrative Law Court

An **informal review** is available before the formal hearing in most jurisdictions. This is often the fastest path to resolution.

If you need a complete evidence packet to support your appeal, AppealDesk can generate one with comparable sales analysis, a cover letter, and filing instructions tailored to your property. Visit https://www.appealdesk.com to get started.



This guide is for informational purposes. Exemption eligibility and program details should be verified with your county assessor's office before applying. Energy rebate programs are subject to change and funding availability. Consult with a tax professional regarding your specific eligibility for tax credits.